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Visual Quality

Visual Quality is about the **rendering itself** — sharpness, framing, light, color, depth of field. Set the prompt and the subject aside for a moment and ask: would this image hold up as a photograph?

Visual Quality is independent of Instruction Following (did the model follow the prompt) and Absence of AI Artifacts (did it hallucinate impossible content). A photo can perfectly match the prompt and still lose on Visual Quality if it's washed out, oversaturated, or unevenly focused.

Visual Quality vs. AI Artifacts

Visual Quality judges the **whole image** — is it sharp, well-lit, well-composed? **AI Artifacts** are **local tells** — bad hands, garbled text, waxy or over-smooth skin. They're separate axes: one bad hand is an **AI Artifacts** problem, **not** a Visual Quality loss. Only lower Visual Quality when the **whole image** looks soft, blurry, or washed out.

What to check

TRY IT

Subject placement, framing, scale, visual hierarchy. The shot should look purposeful, not accidental. Centered isn't always wrong — but ask whether the framing was a choice.

Is the intended subject sharp? Does the blur fall off naturally from the focal point, or is it "blurred" or "faded" all over? Is the image sharp?

Where is the light source? Do all shadows fall consistently from it? Does light type (hard vs. soft) match the apparent light type (hard vs. soft)?

Are colors balanced or pushed past what a real camera would produce? Mixed color temperatures across one scene are a red flag unless the lighting explains them.

Are highlights blown to pure white? Are shadows crushed to pure black? Real photos retain detail at both ends unless intentionally stylized.

At the image's resolution, is fine detail (fabric, skin, foliage) present where it should be, or missing in ways that look like generation failure?

Composition

Composition is how the elements of an image are arranged. Photographers generally use a 3x3 grid: the **rule of thirds** places the subject on one of the gridlines or at an intersection, leaving

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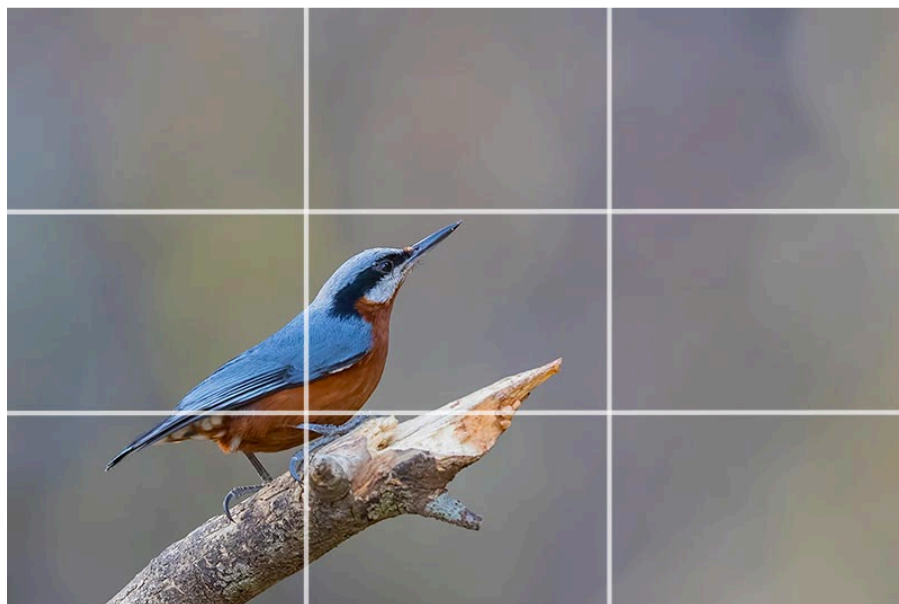
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the other two-thirds more open.



Same photo, side by side — with the rule-of-thirds grid overlaid, the rock lines up on the left gridline rather than dead center.

The right crop evokes more vastness and space, even though technically it's the same image — just shifted. A composition doesn't have to follow textbook rules, but it should look purposeful.



The bird sits at a rule-of-thirds intersection — directing the eye naturally across the frame.

Focus & depth of field

Blur is not always a flaw

Shallow depth of field (blurred background, sharp subject) is a legitimate photographic choice. The question is whether the blur is intentional and *consistent* — not whether it exists.

At **shallow** depth of field (wide aperture, low f-number), only the subject is in focus and the background dissolves into soft blur. At **deep** depth of field (narrow aperture, high f-number), near and far are all sharp at once — typical of landscape or product photography.

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Same portrait, same lighting — only the aperture changed. f/2 isolates the subject; f/22 keeps the whole forest sharp.

In AI-generated images, the background is often **unnaturally** sharp or unevenly focused. Shallow DoF should fall off smoothly from the focus plane — not be patchy or have sharp-edged "halos" around the subject. Those are AI tells under Visual Quality.

Light & color

Light is the most common source of inconsistency in AI-generated images. Check these independently:

What to check	What to look for
Light source direction	Do shadows fall consistently from one source? Is light hitting faces, objects, and background from the same angle?
Softness	Harsh light (direct sun) produces sharp, defined shadows. Diffused light (overcast, studio) produces soft edges. Does shadow quality match the apparent source?



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What to check	What to look for
Contrast	Are highlights blown (pure white, no detail) or shadows crushed (pure black)?
Color temperature	Is the image consistently warm (golden, amber) or cool (blue, gray)? Mixed temperatures across one scene are a red flag unless the lighting explains it.
Saturation	Is color intensity consistent, or do some regions look over-processed while others are flat?

A well-lit image doesn't need to be technically perfect — it needs to be **internally consistent**. Rembrandt lighting is a classic example: one clear light source, the unlit side falls into shadow, and everything in the scene agrees with that source.



Rembrandt lighting — one light source, shadow falling consistently. Shadow direction, skin highlights, and background tone all agree.

Worked example — oversaturation

In the image below, ask: where is the light source? Where are the shadows? Where is the blur supposed to be?

TRY IT



- 1 Cloud detail in a sky that should be dark
- 2 Lights perfectly illuminated
- 3 Coat shadows fall the wrong way
- 4 Car is blurry despite shallow depth of field

Cranked saturation and punchy colors look dramatic, but they're a Visual Quality loss — and a common AI tell. Click

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each point to read the tell.

When colors feel pushed past what a real camera would produce, the image likely has a rendering artifact. Score it down on Visual Quality — and watch for Absence of AI Artifacts (the "filter-applied" look) as a secondary hit.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

Two responses look nearly identical, but one has colors pushed far past what a real camera would produce — overly even lighting, no off-color highlights, too-clean reflections. Which dimensions should this most affect?

Visual Quality (and watch Absence of AI Artifacts for the "filter-applied" look)

Instruction Following — the colors mean the model ignored the prompt

Person ID Preservation — saturation changes who the person is

Check answer

Worked example — blur & distortion

Pick the cleaner response in ambiguous cases.

Prompt: *A mixed-race family having a picnic in a park.* Both look nearly identical at a glance. Zoom into the boy.

Response A	Response B
Response A 	Response B 

Fingers and toes look slightly irregular. Artifact or angle?	Hands and feet are clean. Prefer B.
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You don't need to name the specific artifact. Ambiguous extremity distortion is a known AI tell — pick the cleaner response, don't tie.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

In the picnic example, Response A shows slightly irregular fingers and toes on the boy while Response B's hands and feet look clean. The two are otherwise near-identical. What's the right move?



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Prefer Response B — ambiguous extremity distortion is a known AI tell, so pick the cleaner one

Mark them tied — the difference is too small to call

Prefer Response A — the irregular fingers are likely just the camera angle

Check answer

Watch out for

- **Oversaturation** — unnaturally punchy or over-processed colors.
- **Blown highlights or crushed shadows** — pure white or pure black areas with no detail.
- **Patchy or haloed blur** — depth-of-field falloff that isn't smooth, or sharp-edged transitions around the subject.
- **Mixed color temperature in one scene** — warm and cool light together with no source to explain it.
- **Inconsistent shadow direction** — shadows that don't agree on where the light is coming from.
- **Compositional accidents** — subject centered or cropped in ways that don't read as purposeful.

Related

- [How to See](#) — broader observation framework: composition, focus, light, color.
- [Find realism & artifacts](#) — the *Absence of AI Artifacts* sibling dimension.
- [Omni R2I Elo](#) — full rubric where Visual Quality is one of six axes.

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